1 | Terrorism and the End of British Rule

Zionist policy in Palestine before the Second World War

Key question
What was Zionist policy in Palestine in the late 1930s?

The Jews in Palestine were represented by the **Jewish Agency**. This was effectively the government of the Jewish population in Palestine. It shaped Zionist policy in Palestine: for instance, it made decisions about Jewish settlements and the education of Jewish children. In 1937, the Jewish Agency had agreed to the British plan to divide Palestine into separate Jewish and Arab states. But even then, many Palestinian Jews foresaw that they would have to fight to defend a Jewish state. They knew that the Arabs would never agree to it. Furthermore, some Jewish leaders wanted *all* Palestine to be made into a Jewish state.

Key terms

Jewish Agency
The governing body of the Zionist movement in Palestine during the British mandate.

Stern gang
A Zionist terrorist group founded in 1939.

One of these was David Ben-Gurion, the leader of the Jewish Agency. He accepted the 1937 plan for the partition of Palestine with independent Jewish and Arab states. But he always hoped for more: he assumed that an independent state would allow for unlimited Jewish immigration, the development of a strong economy and the organisation of a powerful army. Then, after that, as he said in a letter to his son:

> I am certain we will be able to settle in all the other parts of the country, whether through agreement and mutual understanding with our Arab neighbours or in another way.

So, although the official policy of the Jewish Agency was to accept a Jewish state in *part* of Palestine, alongside an Arab one, Ben-Gurion and some other leaders hoped for a Jewish state in *all* of Palestine.

In 1939, the British decided *not* to partition Palestine (see page 14). This was a setback to Jewish hopes for a separate Jewish state but the Zionists were not about to give in. They began to campaign against the British policy. Then came the outbreak of the Second World War and most Palestinian Jews decided to support Britain in the fight against Nazi Germany. Many fought in the British army which, in the long term, would enable them to gain valuable military experience and, even, weapons. This would serve them well when the state of Israel was created.

From 1939 onwards, the British were preoccupied with winning the war against Germany. They gave little thought to the future of Palestine and maintained their policy of controlling Jewish immigration so as not to antagonise the Arabs. Then, in 1944, towards the end of the war, a British government committee discussed partition again only to abandon the idea after Lord Moyne, a government minister, was murdered by the **Stern gang**, a Jewish terrorist organisation.

British and Zionist policy after the Second World War

Key question
How did Zionist policy change after the war?

During the war the official Jewish policy in Palestine was to support the British war effort while continuing to campaign